

Golden Hour

A gathering built around one shared sunset – concept brief v1

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The big idea

A 50-150 person gathering for people who make and study time – funders, time researchers, industrial designers, watchmakers, circadian scientists – built around one non-negotiable moment: **everyone watches the sun set into the water together.**

The twist that makes it a *Paragonday* event and not just a nice conference: **the entire program runs on Paragonday time.** No clock times anywhere. Every session is scheduled relative to sunset – "Golden Hour minus 90," "Blue Hour," "After Dark." The schedule literally demonstrates the product's worldview: your day is shaped by the sky, not by a numbered grid.

The sunset is the keynote. Everything before it builds toward it; everything after it glows from it.

Why this works (pressure-test)

Strengths of your instinct:

- *One unrepeatable moment* beats twenty forgettable talks. People remember rituals, not slides. A shared sunset is a ritual with a built-in clock, a built-in climax, and a built-in metaphor for the product.
- *The audience mix is unusually coherent.* Watchmakers, industrial designers, circadian researchers, and time researchers are all "instrument makers for time" from different angles. Funders get a room they can't assemble anywhere else – that's the draw for them.
- *Programming on solar time is cheap to execute and impossible to forget.* It costs printing and discipline, not money.

The honest risks, and their answers:

1. **Clouds.** You cannot book the sun. Answer: pick a venue with an indoor/outdoor flow, and design the ritual so it works on a grey day – the horizon dims, the toast still happens at civil twilight, and the framing becomes "the day ends whether we see it or not." That line belongs in the program.
2. **Geography is strict.** "Sun sinks into the water" rules out most of the East Coast – in NYC the sun sets over New Jersey, not the ocean. See venue section; this is your first real decision.

3. **Funders need more than vibes.** Give them a crisp Paragonday moment (demo at blue hour), curated 1:1 "twilight walk" slots, and a room where every other attendee signals taste. The event *is* the pitch: this founder understands attention, ritual, and design.
4. **Sunset drifts 1-2 minutes per day.** Lock the date before anything gets printed; publish the sunset time as the event's anchor ("Doors at Sunset –3h").

The program (solar schedule)

Example calibrated to a ~6:30pm sunset (early October, Pacific coast):

SOLAR TIME	CLOCK (APPROX)	WHAT HAPPENS
Sunset –3h	3:30	Doors. Sundial check-in, coffee, horology exhibit – watchmakers bring pieces, table by table
Sunset –2h30	4:00	Opening: why we gathered, and the Paragonday worldview (Yatu)
Sunset –2h	4:30	Talks I: a circadian scientist + a time researcher (2 × 20 min, no Q&A – save it for the walks)
Sunset –1h15	5:15	Golden Hour panel: watchmakers × industrial designers – "instruments of time," moderated
Sunset –25m	6:05	Walk to the water. Drinks in hand. Blankets handed out
Sunset –4m	6:26	The Sunset. Silence. No phones. The disc takes ~3 minutes to cross the horizon
Blue Hour	6:35	Toast at civil twilight → the Paragonday demo/launch moment , sky still glowing
After Dark	7:15	Dinner by candle and firelight – amber, circadian-respecting lighting only, zero overhead blue
Night	9:00+	Fire circle, stargazing, unstructured. The people who stay are the ones you want to know

Venue — the first real decision

- **Pacific coast (thematically perfect).** The sun genuinely sinks into the ocean. Standouts: **Scripps Seaside Forum, La Jolla** (a real conference venue on the sand, west-facing, ~150 capacity, indoor/outdoor); Cavallo Point or the Marin Headlands (SF Bay mouth); Ritz Half Moon Bay lawn; a Malibu private venue. SF adds funder density.

- **NYC harbor (logistically easy, thematically 85%).** Sun sets across the water but over land: **Little Island's west-facing amphitheater** over the Hudson is remarkably on-theme; Liberty Warehouse in Red Hook faces the harbor and the Statue of Liberty at dusk. Your network is here; travel cost drops for everyone.
- **Wildcards:** Key West and Cape May are true water-horizon sunsets on the East Coast, but harder travel for the audience you want.

Date idea with a built-in story: the equinox (March 20 or Sept 22, 2027) – the one day the planet splits light and dark evenly. It gives the landing page its headline for free.

Ideas that make it rich

- **No clocks in the venue.** One custom instrument instead: a large analog "time to sunset" dial – a commission for one of the industrial designers on the invite list.
- **Badges** carry your name and the sunset time of your birthplace on the day you were born.
- **A printed field guide** as the program – sunset table, sky glossary (civil/nautical/astronomical twilight), speaker pages. Keepsake, not handout.
- **Lighting follows the sky:** venue color temperature tracks the actual sky through the evening; after dark it never rises above candlelight. The circadian scientists will notice – that's the point.
- **Food follows the light:** bright and citrus in daylight, warm and slow after dark.
- **Branded blankets** for the sunset viewing double as the merch people actually keep.
- **Twilight walks:** 15-minute 1:1 walk slots along the water – the funder-meeting format, disguised as the nicest part of the day.
- **Soft phone ritual:** pouches offered (not forced) for the final hour before sunset.
- **Sound:** silence for the sunset itself; a live ambient set at blue hour.

Scale & budget (rough, honest ranges)

- **~60-person salon:** venue \$10-20k · F&B \$15-20k · AV/production \$6-10k · design/print/merch \$6-8k · travel support for key speakers \$5-10k → **\$45-70k**
- **~120-person summit:** → **\$90-150k**, offset by sponsors that are *on-theme*, *not noisy*: watch brands, Oura / Eight Sleep, lighting companies (Ketra), sleep-science labs.
- **Model:** application/invite-only, ticket priced \$150-350 to signal seriousness; funders and speakers comped. Scarcity is the marketing.

The landing page (next step, and it writes itself)

- Headline counts down in **sunsets, not days**: "43 sunsets until Golden Hour."
- The page background renders the visitor's **local sky right now** – direct reuse of the Sky Agenda prototype. The marketing site *is* a product demo.
- Single CTA: **Request an invitation.** Short application, no public ticket link.

- Speaker reveals one per week, each announced "at golden hour" local time.

Open decisions (in order)

1. **Coast:** Pacific (true sun-into-water, funder density in SF) vs NYC harbor (your network, 85% of the theme)?
2. **Date:** equinox 2027, or sooner?
3. **Is this the Paragonday launch moment,** or does the product ride along at blue hour without carrying the event?
4. Invite-only application vs ticketed – I lean application.